called me on to the mezzanine where the two sat having food. He then introduced me to Pant as ‘my Princetonian’. Sarabhai was obviously not bothered about the seniors watching the three of us chit chat in the exclusive zone, since he sincerely felt I deserved appreciation. He must have done the same to several other deserving scientists.

Hierarchy meant little to Sarabhai who would casually drop by at my—and many others’—desk for a chat or take me for a stroll along the Thumba beach to discuss something. Still struggling to let the tragic news sink in, I remembered the day the handsome man in white kurta-pajama stood before me, a rookie engineer working on an explosive bolt at TERLS in 1967. His first words to me rang in my ears, ‘They call me Vikram.’

Having reconciled with Sarabhai’s death, now I wanted to know about his last hours. Sarabhai, staying at Halcyon Castle, a British era bungalow tucked away on the campus of a luxurious hotel overlooking the Arabian Sea, had met a few scientists the previous night, the last one being B Ramakrishna Rao, a contemporary of Kalam. I met Rao, but instead of a hint of the cause of Sarabhai’s death, I was let into the sad tale of Rao who lost in Sarabhai, his last resort to prove his innocence over charges of misappropriation in ISRO.

Rao told me Sarabhai had been meeting several people, as usual, giving instructions and listening to their concerns. Rao had a grievance: he was accused of taking away from VSSC an air-conditioner and a few equipment to his house without permission. This amounted to stealing. Rao told me that he had indeed taken some gadgets home, but not the air-conditioner, with oral permission from Sarabhai who understood that Rao, a senior scientist, could at time work from home.

I believe in Rao’s tale, for I know he was a conscientious scientist. I also knew Sarabhai’s style of functioning, often giving permission to do things and getting the paperwork done later so as not to delay work. Sarabhai didn’t disregard the bureaucratic system, but he bent it as he willed to enhance efficiency. I remembered how he had constituted a committee and made it approve my Princeton education within a few hours, and how he pulled strings at RBI to arrange for foreign exchange within a day. Not too different was the way Sarabhai ensured that I got the NASA fellowship money, which the